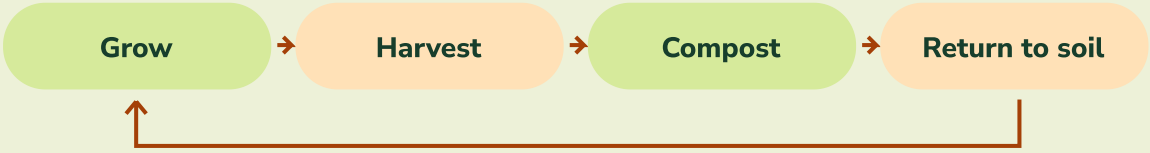
Organic growing: the core ideas

Organic growing begins with a useful bit of housekeeping: keep as much plant material as possible in the garden, turn it into compost and return it to the soil. Then pay attention to what grows well there.

Keep useful material in the garden



Return suitable scraps and plant waste. Add outside compost when the garden cannot make enough.

Look after the ground

Use mature compost to improve the soil and replenish what crops take from it. Keep feet and barrow wheels on the paths. Dig or no-dig can both be part of this approach; choose a method that suits the soil and the work you can comfortably do.

Work with the place you have

A plant in the right conditions usually needs less rescuing. Grow the crops and varieties that suit your ground, give them room, and avoid pushing seedlings out into cold, wet soil. Keep a record of successes as well as failures. It is remarkably easy to forget the name of a good variety.

Deal with the cause

Look closely before reaching for a remedy. Check moisture, roots and recent weather, then use the appropriate Troubles guide. Hand-pick damaging pests where practical and fit suitable crop protection. Keep bird netting taut and check it regularly; loose loops can trap the birds you wanted to exclude.

Experiment on a small patch

A thick hay-and-straw mulch that works well in a drier climate can shelter slugs on cold, wet ground. Try new ideas on a manageable area before changing the whole garden. Keep what works, understand why it works, and feel free to adapt it.

John: Into the Zone; both 35 Years videos; Why We Make Compost. Canonical organic controls.